

have a copy of your most vital data stored elsewhere as a backup. Most users these days will inevitably end up having a couple of email accounts — such as Gmail and Outlook, for example — which also enable access to their respective cloud drives.

So, even if your GDrive access is down for some reason, you can still access a backup copy from your OneDrive account.



UNIFY CLOUD STORAGE ACCESS

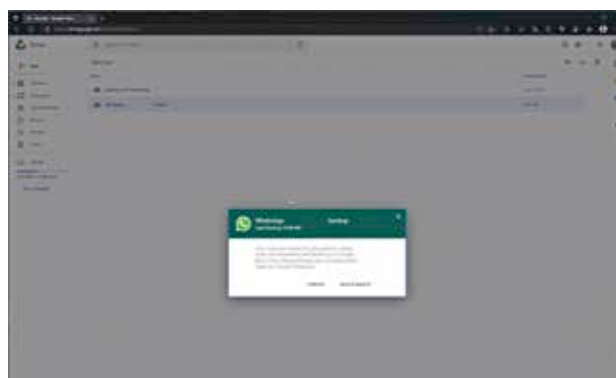
With a major chunk of our computing needs being taken online, the reliance on the cloud has never been higher. We often find ourselves subscribing to several cloud providers and managing these can quickly become frustrating. This is where some consolidation helps.

Services such as ODrive, Storage Made Easy, Multi-Cloud, Air Cluster, and more offer to consolidate all your cloud storage accounts, such as GDrive, OneDrive, Dropbox, Box, Mega, etc. into one unified interface with a single logon as a combined storage pool. You can drag and drop files into this storage pool and decide which cloud those files should land in. Many of these services also allow for collaboration, transferring data from one cloud to another, and even advanced encryption depending on the pricing tier chosen. Popular file transfer apps such as FileZilla Pro also offer the ability to integrate various cloud providers apart from the usual FTP and sFTP sites, so you can manage everything from a single interface.



UNSYNC TO SAVE LOCAL STORAGE

Those heavily invested into cloud services may prefer to



Device and app backups in Google Drive

go with lesser offline storage. But if you keep all files in sync, your local storage will fill up soon as well. If you are using Windows and use OneDrive, a nifty way around this is to download files on demand and unsync them when the job is done. Check your OneDrive settings in case you don't see this option already.

Other providers may offer a similar feature as well. For example, Google Drive has a Stream files option pretty much mimics OneDrive's Files On-Demand functionality.



CREATE YOUR OWN CLOUD

All said and done, the cloud storage solutions we often use belong to third-parties, and most of them have some clause in their usage terms that give them rights to look at your data to ensure you aren't misusing their service. Although the services themselves often do not have any bandwidth caps, accessing them from your network and syncing them to tens of devices can be quite slow.

Those who are extremely privacy and speed conscious would do best with a homebrew cloud solution. The answer lies in creating your own FTP server.

The detailed procedure to create one merits a full article of its own. But suffice to say, creating your own FTP solu-

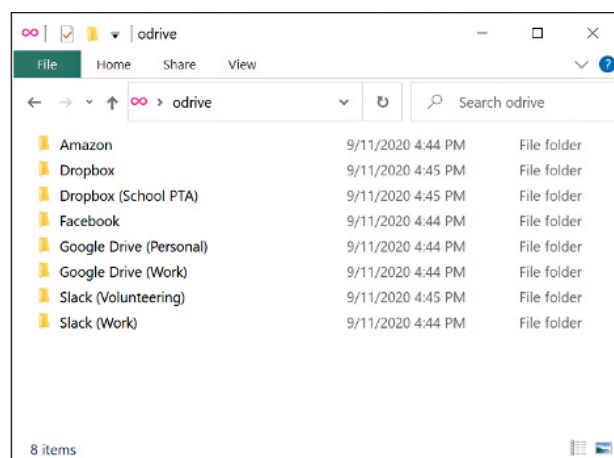
tion is not that hard. All you need is a configurable router, a computer running Windows XP or later/macOS 10.13.2 or later/Linux, FileZilla Server, and an FTP/sFTP client for your smartphone or tablet.

Designate a folder on your computer's storage or NAS that will serve as a shared folder. Install FileZilla Server, add the required shared folders to sync, give appropriate read/write permissions, and set up a username and password. You may need to allow exception for FileZilla in the Windows or your OS's firewall.

earlier configured on the server. Your personal cloud is almost setup. However, this works only when the server and clients are on the same network. If you want to have access to these files while on the move, you need to configure your router's firewall to allow incoming connections to the FTP port configured in the server or setup what is known as a demilitarized zone (DMZ) to direct all incoming packets to the server computer.

Some of the more advanced routers with USB ports also allow you to connect a USB storage drive and use that as a networked cloud drive, an iTunes server, or a media server. Several OEMs even offer their own solutions that sync the USB storage attached to the router with a cloud service.

While the concept of a local FTP cloud is enticing, some of the advantages diminish when you access files from outside your network. Also, you should factor



Note your computer's IP address and try to access the same via an FTP/sFTP client from your smartphone/tablet/other devices. The client should have automatic sync options to and from a designated folder on the client to one that was

in the costs of keeping your server PC running. They are also not hassle-free when it comes to giving others access to your files. An ideal setup would be a combination of private and public clouds that help you stay in sync with your data wherever you go. 